Word formation and reference words

Understand it

In completion tasks the missing word must fit the grammar of the sentence. Before you search, decide whether you need a noun, verb, adjective or adverb, singular or plural.

Reference words (this, it, they, the former) connect sentences. Understanding what they point back to is often the key to a Reading answer.

The rules

- Gap-fills need the right word class. Predict it first: after the, a noun or adjective; after to, a verb; after is, an adjective or -ing.
- Suffixes: nouns -tion, -ment, -ness, -ity, -er; verbs -ize, -en, -ify; adjectives -ful, -less, -ous, -able, -al; adverbs -ly.
- Reference words stand for something mentioned: this, that, these, those, it, they, which, the former, the latter, such.
- To understand a reference, look back to the nearest noun that fits in number and meaning.

All the words and forms you need

Noun suffixes	-tion · -sion · -ment · -ness · -ity · -ance · -ence · -er / -or · -ist · -ism · -ship
Verb suffixes	-ize · -ise · -en · -ify · -ate
Adjective suffixes	-ful · -less · -ous · -ive · -able · -ible · -al · -ic · -ent
Adverb suffix	-ly
Reference words	it · its · they · them · this · that · these · those · such · the former · the latter · the above · which
Prediction clues	the / a + adj + ___ (noun) · to ___ (verb) · is very ___ (adjective) · ___ly (adverb)

Where you use it

Reading: In matching headings, reference words show the paragraph continues the same topic.

Listening: Predict whether the missing word is a noun, number or adjective.

Writing: Use this / these with a noun: This trend, These figures.

Speaking: Use that is why, which is why to link ideas.

More examples

- The ___ of the bridge took five years. (noun: construction)
- Scientists want to ___ the results. (verb: confirm)

- The new method is more ___ than the old one. (adjective: effective)
- Bees pollinate crops. Without them, ... (them = bees)
- Paris and Rome are popular; the latter has more museums. (the latter = Rome)

Common mistakes

WRONG	RIGHT
✗ a very success company	✓ a very successful company
✗ This are important.	✓ This is important. / These are important.
✗ He is a good teach.	✓ He is a good teacher.

Speaking practice: answer using this grammar

1. Make three words from 'create' and use them in sentences.
2. Describe a problem and say 'this means that ...'
3. Compare two cities using the former / the latter.

Writing practice

Make noun, verb, adjective and adverb from: success, product, create, care.

Practice

1. Noun from decide: _____
2. Adjective from care: _____
3. Verb from strong: _____
4. Adverb from quick: _____
5. What does it refer to? The city grew fast. It is now huge. _____
6. What does the latter refer to? Tea and coffee are popular; the latter is stronger. _____

Answers

1. decision
2. careful / careless
3. strengthen
4. quickly
5. the city
6. coffee